Lecture 36 — Course Review

Jeff Zarnett
jzarnett@uwaterloo.ca

Department of Electrical and Computer Engineering
University of Waterloo

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Exam Coverage

The exam is based on material we have covered in the lectures & assignments.

The exam is cumulative: covers from the first lecture to the last.

Assignments 1 through 4 are included.

Terms & Conditions

This is an open-book, calculators allowed, exam.

Bring your notes (or ours, or both), but be reasonable about what you print.

But it's still written by hand, on paper.

The exam is about applying concepts, not memorizing trivia.

How to Prepare

How to prepare for the final exam:

1. Review lecture notes and slides, and flipped class notes.
2. Review assignments – especially if LLMs helped a lot.
3. Try old exams (2024 had an in-person one).
4. Ask for help if you need it (Piazza).

Exam Tips

Tips for the Exam:

1. At this point, you know what works well for you – do that!
2. A small amount of well-organized notes is better than tons of random info.
3. Take the time to read the question carefully.
4. You can use point form instead of full sentences on written questions.

breathing noises

I say this to my 2nd year students:

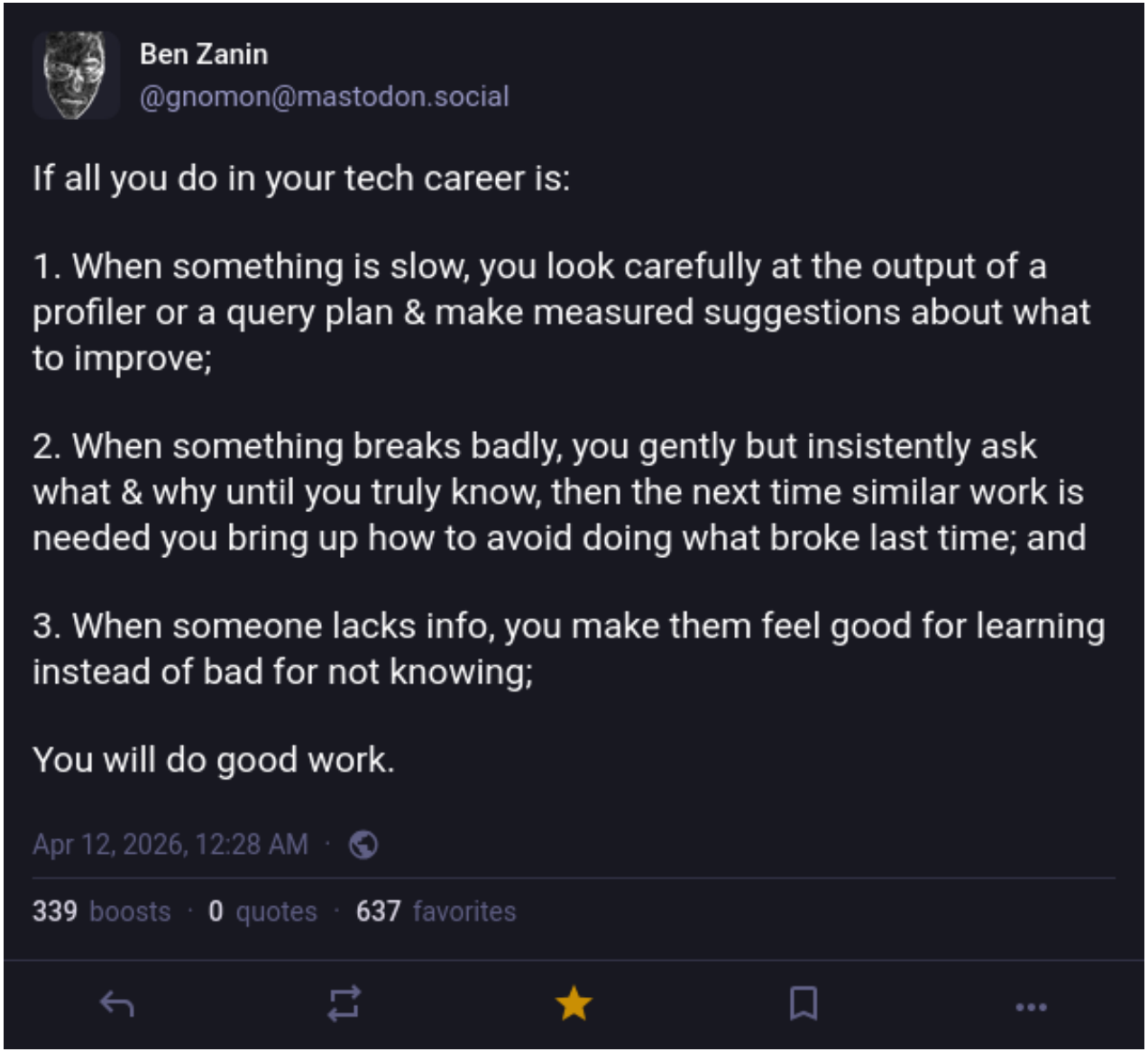
“The Force is with you, young Skywalker...
But you are not a Jedi yet.”

lightsaber turns off

But you're 4th year students. And now you can say:

"I am a Jedi, like my father before me."

Do Good Work



Ben Zanin
@gnomon@mastodon.social

If all you do in your tech career is:

1. When something is slow, you look carefully at the output of a profiler or a query plan & make measured suggestions about what to improve;

2. When something breaks badly, you gently but insistently ask what & why until you truly know, then the next time similar work is needed you bring up how to avoid doing what broke last time; and

3. When someone lacks info, you make them feel good for learning instead of bad for not knowing;

You will do good work.

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More Good Work

Ben Zanin
@gnomon@mastodon.social

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Of course you can aim higher. It doesn't feel like the glory days of early computerization where a week in the server closet can change the world, but there are still a million ways we can make things work better in the large and in the small.

But you can do a lot of good by doing the basics really well. People will thank you for it, sincerely, because it's more than many folks contribute. You can set a good example, you can hold out a helping hand; you can prove it's not a zero-sum game.

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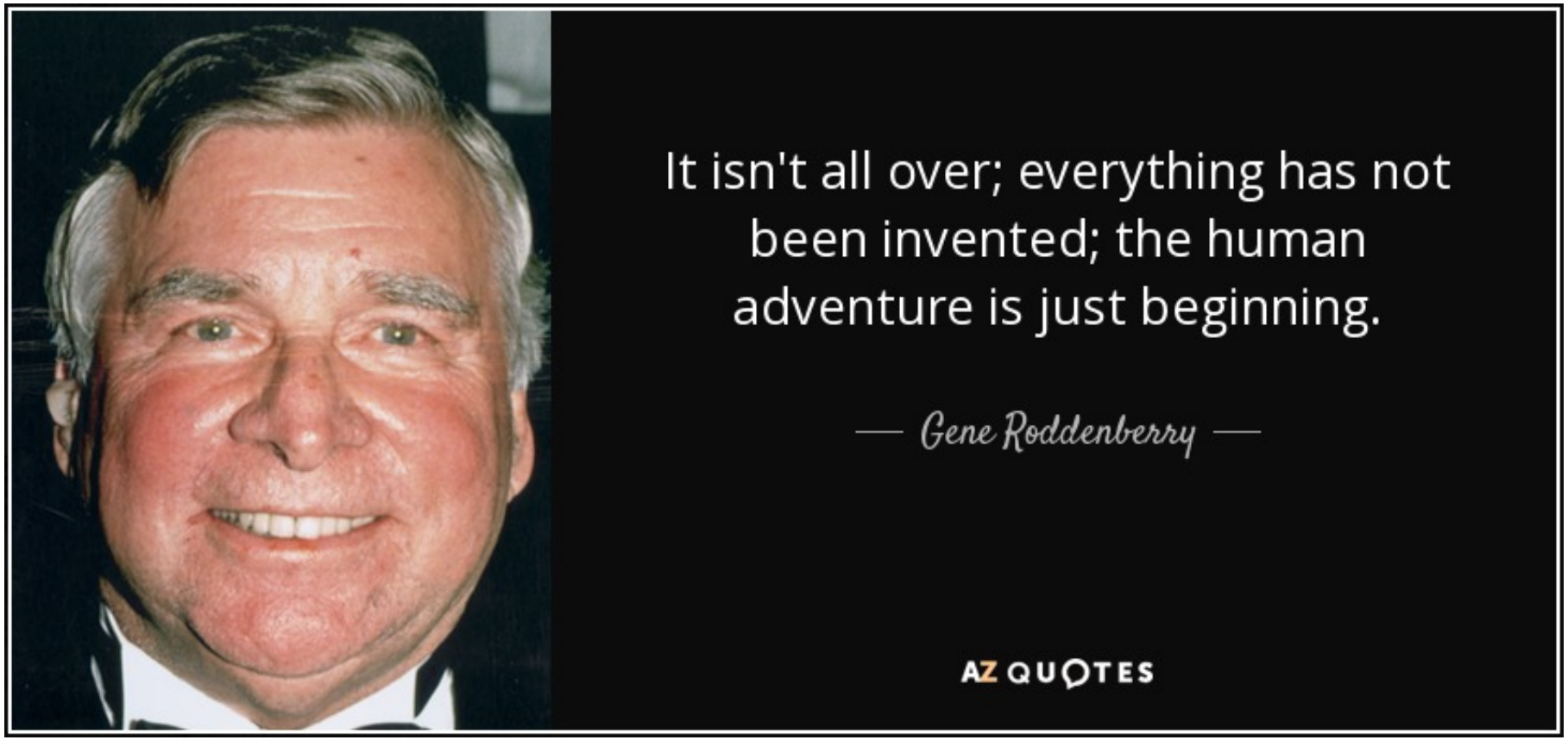
The Human Adventure is Just Beginning